

RSM — Just-DDJ Chain (v9.2)

Correspondence register. $::$ denotes imperfect structural correspondence — never identity, translation-equivalence, or congruence; substitution is forbidden. Stratum tags: **[G]** attested in the Guodian bundles (~300 BCE); **[R]** received-text or Mawangdui only.

Evidential posture. The DDJ is generatively upstream of the framework — the author built the framework through the text — so agreement between them carries no public evidential weight. The text is the subject of a translation, not a witness; this chain's success criterion is translation-fidelity, independent of the derivation's criterion. What the text *can* supply as evidence is resistance: manuscript readings that refuse a correspondence, and preregistered tests scored against the strips.

The instrument. Text and notation are two compressions with non-overlapping failure modes; each audits the other. Text→math at the notation layer (two lexical items against one symbol: flag a candidate distinction; the math must then verify with its own resources) and math→commentary at the reading layer (structural coherence discriminates rival glosses) are legitimate. Text→math at the premise layer and math→text at the attestation layer are forbidden: no character enters a derivation; no structure overrides the strips.

The referent: 道

道 :: **the recursive structural model itself** — the structure entailed by P_0 's standing non-obtaining ("P₀ has never obtained, does not obtain, and will never obtain" — three tenses as the in-frame rendering of a tenseless modal fact; the text's tenseless grammar states it natively). 常道 :: **the entailment as such, unindexed.** 可道 :: **any framed statement or traversal of it.** Consequences: 道法自然 — a structure grounded in an impossibility needs nothing to hold it up; an impossibility cannot lapse, be consumed, or require maintenance (谷神不死, 用之不勤 as entailments, not praise). In Chapter 25's dual styling, 道 is the model and 大 its first instance, R_1 .

The opening: 道可道非常道 [R — Ch. 1 not in Guodian]

Heading-and-theorem: the frame-relative is not the frame-independent. $\forall X$: 可X 非 常X.

- 常 :: frame-independent, parameter-free (register marker; not "eternal"). The oldest stratum reads 恆 (persisting-across); see the checksum item on 恆/常.

- 可 :: frame-relative, parametric, indexed within the frame. (The modes are magnitudes; a sign is an indexed comparison. This is the text's own testimony — its conjugate pairs are co-present magnitudes throughout, and no negative quantities appear anywhere in it.)
- 非 :: the divergence of two registers around a shared invariant. In the only copular uses the text contains (Ch. 1's two), 非 stands between two readings of one term — 可道 非 常道 — and its middle is the invariant both flanks share. The survey: 非 is rare (on the order of six tokens in five chapters); the non-copular tokens are rhetorical (Ch. 7), purposive (Ch. 65), class-negation (Ch. 31), predicative (Ch. 53); 是非 as a compound does not occur; **no token negates between conjugate opposites**. *[survey run against the corpus; Guodian graphs to be verified against facsimiles]*

The corpus contributes here by **resistance**, which is the one thing this chain may supply as evidence: the text refuses the mirror-negative reading, in that the construction such a reading predicts is absent from every token. Structurally the mode-swap's fixed point is the invariant itself, which is what the copular grammar puts in the middle. The two accounts agree; only the philological one carries weight.

Line 2: 名可名非常名. 常名 :: $XY = 1$, the unindexed law; 可名 :: $X_n Y_n = 1_n$, the same law indexed. The 可/常 split applied to the law itself. *[candidate]*

Lines 3–4. The Mawangdui manuscripts read 萬物 in both clauses (the Shiji quotes the line that way; 天地 is the received substitution). One referent, twice related: **始 and 母 are the two relations** the unnamed and the named bear to the ten thousand things — what conditions them and what keeps constituting them — i.e., the derivation's two mechanisms: identity-through-opposition at the ground; generation-at-the-joint thereafter. 始 :: O_n (the unmet origin, prior to any position); 母 :: P_n (the generative persisting locus, the parent-side of 生). Shared 女 :: the center-role genus; different determinatives :: the two species. *[R; convergence, P2]*

The methodology lines (常無欲以觀其妙 / 常有欲以觀其微) **[R]**: two observational vantages, one from each face, both required — the parallax method stated inside the text. 欲 :: directed orientation, zero agency; 妙 :: relational pattern (the 無-vantage); 微 :: boundary (the 有-vantage). Philological exposure carried: this reading requires the split parsing (常無, 欲...); the Mawangdui phrase-grouping leans toward the unit parsing (恆無欲...), and no older stratum arbitrates. *[falsifiable at the manuscript layer; cited only with this exposure attached]*

有無相生 [G — Ch. 2, slip A15; 亡 for 無; the shorter formulation]

有 :: the form mode; 無 :: the void mode — two co-present magnitudes with the gradient reading 有 $\times$ 無 = 1_n . Neither reaches zero; each is constituted by the other; every position carries both. Void is not zero: zero is the center, where both modes would vanish; 無 as

mode is a bounded, shaped, functional magnitude (Ch. 11: 有之以為利，無之以為用 — the conserved product in nine words). Guodian 亡 (relational absence) fits the mode reading better than received 無; the drift 亡→無 runs toward exactly the confusion this register discipline guards against.

Chapter 2 is also the method: no definitions, six conjugate pairs listed, each arising mutually, the one relation induced from six instances — how a mutually-constituted circle is entered, since it cannot be derived into from outside. The chapter with the oldest witness carries the structural heart; the staged cosmogony (Ch. 42) is absent from the strips.

Chapter 40 [G — slip A37; the scored test]

The slip reads: 返也者道僅也 / 溺也者道甬也 / 天下之勿生於又生於亡。

- **The engine lines are definitions.** Both carry the 也者...也 formula — the classical definitional construction: “Returning — it is the pattern’s movement; 溺-ing — it is the pattern’s function.” The received text strips the stamps to bare assertions; the 也-erosion, documented at the two most load-bearing lines in the text.
- **返** (return-in-motion, the walker radical), where the received has 反. 反/返 :: the turn along G around the unmet center — circulation, the in-frame face of the engine. Which of 反/復 names return-of-structure versus return-of-place is a checksum item; the two-returns theorem it was keyed to is [rendering] on the math side, so the checksum may be a purely lexical question.
- **溺 — attested-uninterpreted.** The graph is 溺, not 弱 (the inventory’s 弱 was the received normalization). The interpretive ladder is mandatory and unfilled: (1) 溺’s Chu-period semantic range; (2) its local reading, framework-blind; (3) only then any correspondence. A37 is the highest-projection-risk location in the corpus. [*no :: assigned*]
- **The preregistered test, scored positive.** The preregistration: if the strip reads symmetrically (生於有，生於亡), the older text sits on the modal side and the received hierarchy (有生於無) is the later emendation. The transcription shows **no second 有**: born of 有, born of 亡 — the balanced parallel. The oldest witness reads co-emergence; the staged arrow was added in transmission. Threats to validity, carried: (i) haplography — a repeated 有 is the classic eye-skip environment; against it, the 3+3 balance, the definitional framing of the preceding lines, and Ch. 2’s 相生 on the same bundle; (ii) **the Mawangdui bracket — whether the silk texts carry the repetition dates the emendation; the facsimiles are unchecked, and the date is not to be cited until they are.** The finding stands on the transcription; only the dating waits. Consequence: 生 at this line reads as co-emergence, and the three-forms taxonomy below is untouched.

The cluster: 玄 / 牝 / 玄牝 [G — 玄 attested, slip A08; 玄牝 R]

玄 :: Paradox :: P_n . 牝 :: generative. 玄牝 :: generative paradox :: P_0 . The compound is compositional — the character for paradox plus the character for generative capacity computes the name of the generative paradox — so the assignment is motivated, not brute. The differentiator: every P_n has two faces (in-frame organizing locus; trans-frame seat); P_0 , unframed, has no in-frame face — it is *purely* generative, and 牝 marks that purity (可以為天下母; 玄牝之門是謂天地根: the mother of the whole tree). 玄之又玄 :: **the species iterated** — paradox at every joint of the tree: the reduplication reads as the recursion itself. 眾妙之門 (Ch. 1) and 玄牝之門 (Ch. 6): 門 at exactly the two places the structure has gates — the recursion's and the ground's.

The three generative forms, one ratio, three mechanisms, never conflated: (1) entailment-生 :: the ground, $P_0 : O_1$ (道生一 — 道 is not a mother; P_0 has no prior state); (2) parturition-生 :: $P_n \rightarrow P_n, O_{(n+1)}$ (severance with a persisting parent); (3) 相生 :: mutual constitution within the frame. 生 $\neq$ 相生; entailment-生 $\neq$ parturition-生.

The count: 道生一，一生二，二生三，三生萬物 [R — Ch. 42 not in Guodian]

Exposition-order, never event-order. 一 :: the first distinction; 二 :: the two modes (nothing added — the two came with the one); 三 :: **the pair plus its bond** — the text's own gloss in the next line, 沖氣以為和: the blend, not a third mode and not a third axis. The three's seat is the joint, and children stand at the joint in the text's own exposition — commentary on how it counts, not a structural siting, since generation has no address. 三生萬物 because only a held relation is able to be referred to. The chapter's staging is absent from the oldest witness; read as a timeline it re-imports what the strips refuse.

天地不仁; 守中 [mixed strata — only the bellows lines are strip-attested (A23)]

天地 :: G_n ; 天地不仁 :: no preferred position along the gradient [R]. Extended to the tree: no preferred frame — every trunk is a branch of its parent and every branch a trunk to its children, save a root (each obtained tree is rooted; O_1 's parent-side is P_0 , an impossibility, not a frame; the ground is exempt by mechanism, not favored). The bellows (虛而不屈，動而愈出) :: the functional void, strip-attested [G]. 守中 :: B_n — the balance structure through both centers; descriptive, not prescriptive [R].

弗居 [G — slip A17; the strongest strip-attested match in the

chain]

成而弗居: completes, yet structurally-cannot-dwell. 成 :: met-at-resolution (the completion is real); 弗居 :: the origin-denial (弗, structural impossibility — exactly not 不, contingent negation). The engine's two-denial structure, in two characters, on a strip. 無為 :: aligned persistence; 為 :: effortful action under misalignment.

此兩者同出而異名 [R]

Same origin, different register — the slice identity is its sharpest reading: the gradient and the orbit are literally 同出 (one law) 而異名 (two slices, two names); 同謂之玄 — the shared origin is viewed at the seat, where the slices coincide: 玄's own locus. Two names for one law is exactly what an indexed second reading is. *[convergence remark; never flows backward as support]*

The 法 cascade [G — slip A23]

人法地，地法天，天法道，道法自然. 法 :: the child-parent structural relation at the joint — pattern-taking, not substance-transfer, which is what the cross-frame share is. 道法自然 :: the terminus of the regress of grounds — the model takes its pattern from its own self-sufficiency, because beneath an impossibility there is nothing to stand on. 域中有四大: the fourth term 王 not yet derived. *[open]*

The anthology as curriculum [G]

Bundle A's first unit is one physically continuous written entity (the text runs across slips; internal order secured): 19 → 66 → 46 → 30 → 15 → 64 → 37 → 63 → 2 → 32. It opens with 絕智棄辯 — discard cleverness and *disputation* (the Guodian wording; the received retargeting at Confucian virtues is the later layer) — passes through 為無為 (practice the paradoxical mode), and arrives at the six pairs (the structural primer). Entrance, practice, structure: the received arrangement opens by *declaring* the limit of the instrument (Ch. 1); the older arrangement opens by *commanding* its abandonment — and the instrument it names, 辯, is the one the circle at the base defeats. The unit-arrangement within the bundle is editorial; the sequence within the unit is physical. Section-break data adds: chapters 15→64 and 64→56 flow with no marker — originally continuous teaching.

Verbal and stamp discipline

In prose without :: , correspondence is "to me, that looks just like...", never "X is Y." 也 (the Guodian 也者...也 definitional stamp) :: the derivation's own ≡; the multi-century stripping of

也 (Guodian → Mawangdui → received) is the tradition treating theorems as observations, one copyist at a time — documented at the engine lines themselves (Ch. 40, above).

The etymology guard

Two operations look alike and are not. **Recovering an earlier attested state** — the strip against the received text — is scoreable: Ch. 40's parallel and the 也-erosion are both of this kind, with manuscript evidence on both sides. **Inferring a pre-attested sense from a graph's picture** is not scoreable: there is no witness for the stage being reconstructed, and the graph may belong to a different word than the one it came to write. The second operation does not enter this chain. Worked instance, declined: 萬 is a scorpion pictogram borrowed for a homophonous number-word, and the number-word has its own etymology in the sense-field of *vast, entire, multifarious*. The reading "myriad rather than the integer ten thousand" is well supported — on ordinary lexical grounds, which is the route this chain takes. No graphic-origin argument is used.

Open checksum items

- 反/復 — which return-word names return-of-structure and which return-of-place. *[open; lexical, structural stake reduced]*
- 恆/常 — invariance-across-frames (恆, per the 互 paleography) vs. invariance-within-frame (常). *[open]*
- 生/成 — the child-origin obtaining vs. the child frame completing (大器曼成). *[open]*
- 亡/無 — relational absence as a third absence-type; candidate referent: the parent-frame reading of a seat whose child obtains. *[open]*
- 溺 — the interpretive ladder, unfilled. *[open]*
- **The Mawangdui facsimiles** — the one outstanding errand behind a scored result. *[open; blocking only the dating of the Ch. 40 emendation]*

v9.2 — the chains state the framework as currently known; the editorial record holds how it got here.